the street corner, waved to him. Mathur grinned. Finally, his most daring operation in the USA would begin.

At thirty-eight, Mathur had been a R&AW operative for almost a decade, travelling across the world to carry out the tasks assigned by his bosses. His ability to infiltrate unknown territories in foreign lands, track down targets and sniff out information without inviting attention seemed almost inborn. He was straightforward, avoided using the jargon of espionage and had a knack for thinking on his feet that made him one of the agency's most revered figures. On his arrival in Washington that January, Mathur's first task was to track down Jagjit Singh Chohan, a former Punjab politician and the face of the Khalistan movement abroad since the 1970s.

Sartaj, a long time R&AW informer, had been horrified when Mathur asked him to set up a meeting with Chohan. He warned Mathur that it would be a bad idea for him to openly meet the fifty-nine-year-old militant leader who had a free run in the USA and was famous for his ruthlessness. But Mathur did not care about possible personal repercussions. Washington was becoming a haven for fleeing Sikh militant leaders and Mathur had been told by his bosses to make direct contact with them without concealing his identity. In an operation where no cover is provided, the risks are great.

Mathur patiently waited for two months before Chohan agreed to meet him. When Sartaj finally phoned him that morning, it had been out of the blue. Mathur had not planned his agenda for the meeting and the prospect of a disaster shadowed his thoughts.

When Mathur and Sartaj were ushered to the drawing room where Chohan was sitting on a corner sofa, surrounded by